Operations Fundamentals · Module 2

Recording script.

Running time about 11 minutes read aloud, closer to 13 once you pause and draw, in three chapters. Record each chapter as its own Loom if that's easier; the timings beside each slide are a guide, not a target. ▸ marks a stage direction: pause, look up, or draw on paper. Say it in your own words; the script is there so you never lose the thread. The employment points on slide 10 were checked against GOV.UK and The Pensions Regulator in November 2026.

Opening

1 If it lives in your head, it leaves when you do.

0:36

▸ Camera on, slide up. Welcome back. Module 1 was the whole ball. This one is the first pair: the work. Process and people. By the end you'll have one task out of your head and written down, tested by someone who's never done it, and handed over with a decision and a limit. And you'll have checked that everyone who works for you has the basics in place. About 12 minutes, three chapters, then the worksheet. Have your module 1 map next to you.

2 You're off for two weeks. What breaks?

0:23

Before we start. Imagine you're off for two weeks from tomorrow, properly off, phone in a drawer. What breaks? **▸ Pause.** Not what slows down. What actually stops, or goes wrong, because only you know how to do it. Write it down. That's the task we're working on for the rest of this module.

Chapter 1 · Get it out of your head

3 Get it out of your head.

0:09

Chapter 1, about four minutes. How the work really gets done, and how to write it down so it's actually used.

4 “Fill as needed.”

1:05

▸ Look up. I joined a scale-up as roughly the thirtieth person. Within two years it had over three hundred. From the outside it looked fantastic: investors wanted fast growth, and we grew fast. But the whole plan depended on one big regulatory approval coming through, and there was no plan B. No starting small and building as we needed. Teams were given budgets and told, fill as needed. So they filled seats. Then the approval didn’t come. What followed felt like panic: new plans, new markets, one after another. And there wasn’t enough work for the people we’d hired. By the time I was made redundant, there had been two rounds of redundancies. From where I sat, it wasn’t that nobody could see the whole. Nobody was asked to. A role should exist because there’s work for it, and that work should be written down. That’s what this module is about.

5 Trigger

0:51

Before you write anything, map one process. Three things. The trigger: the event that starts it. Not ‘monthly’ or ‘when needed’. An event. The handoffs: every point the work changes hands, because that’s where it gets dropped. And the record: the proof it happened. Take Kestrel, our events agency from module 1. Invoicing starts when the client signs off an event. It goes from the account manager to the founder, who raises the invoice, to the client. The record is the invoice in the client folder and the tracker saying Invoiced. The middle steps mostly take care of themselves once you know those three.

▸ On paper: trigger on the left, record on the right, an arrow for every handoff.

6 Steps last.

0:38

When founders write a process down, they start with the steps. Log in, click here, fill this in. That’s why most SOPs get ignored. Steps are the part anyone could copy. Start instead with why it exists and what done well looks like. Why it exists is the line that makes people follow it when nobody’s checking. For Kestrel: we pay venues up front, so every day an invoice is late, we’re funding the client. Once that’s clear, you only need to write the steps someone would get wrong.

7

0:45

1

There are nine questions every good SOP answers. They're in the SOP guide, with a weak and a strong answer for each, so I won't go through all of them. Two matter most. Question 2, why it exists, because that's what makes people follow it. And question 8: what can they decide alone, and when do they stop and ask? If you only hand over the steps and keep the decisions, the work comes back to you. We'll come back to that in chapter 3. One rule for all nine: if you can answer it without thinking about your own business, you haven't answered it yet.

8

0:33

Give it to someone who's never done it.

Then test it. Give it to a capable person who has never done the task, and watch them do it once, without helping. That last bit is the hard part. Every question they ask is a gap. Every step they skip needs a reason written next to it. Every place they hesitate needs a name, a number or a link. Fix those and test again. A copied template fails this on the first step. Yours shouldn't.

Chapter 2 · The people basics

9

0:09

The people basics.

Chapter 2, about two minutes. The things everyone who works for you should have in place, whatever size you are.

10 A written contract

1:33

Four things for everyone who works for you. I'm keeping this to recognising them, not the detail. One: a written contract. Employees and workers must get a written statement of their main terms on their first day, with the rest within two months. Two: right to work. You check it before they start, and you keep a record of the check, including the date. The penalty is up to forty-five thousand pounds per worker for a first breach. And since October, the rules reach further, including some contractors. Three: payroll and pension. Employees are paid through payroll and reported to HMRC. Eligible staff are enrolled in a workplace pension, and you pay in too. Four: a clear role. One line saying what they own. That one isn't law. It's what stops two people doing the same job, or nobody doing it. One change to know about: from January 2027, employees can claim unfair dismissal after six months in the job, not two years. So your contracts, your probation and your one-line roles matter from the start. If someone works for you as a contractor, make sure that's genuinely what they are. It's different in the US. If you're unsure on any of this, it's an employment adviser's question, and module 4 covers when to call one.

11 If it isn't written down, it isn't agreed.

0:25

The point of all four is the same as the SOP. If it isn't written down, it isn't agreed. It's a memory, and two people will remember it differently. Most people problems I see in small teams start there: a role nobody wrote down, a promise made on a call, a contract that was meant to be sorted later.

Chapter 3 · Hand it over

12 Hand it over.

0:10

Chapter 3, about four minutes. Writing it down isn't the same as handing it over. This is how you make it stay handed over.

13

0:37

1

Most handovers come back for one of three reasons. One: the task left, but the decision didn't. They can do the work, but every judgement call still comes to you. Two: nobody checked they could. You explained it once and hoped, and the first mistake sends it straight back. Three: checking and fixing got blurred. They spot a problem but aren't allowed to fix it, so it lands back on your desk. Think about the last thing you handed over that came back. Which one was it?

14

0:45

1

So, four steps, in order. One: show them one real example, and think out loud while you do it. Say why you check what you check. They're learning your judgement, not your clicks. Two: they teach it back. They do the next one while you watch, and you ask what they'd change, what they'd test first, and where they still need you. Three: split who checks from who fixes, and agree what stops it going out. Four: hand over the decision, with a limit. This builds on David's Handover step: hand over the decisions, not just the tasks. The handover kit walks you through each one.

15

0:38

"Use your judgement, but run anything big past me."

Here's step four with Kestrel. The founder hands invoicing to an account manager. The weak version: use your judgement, but run anything big past me. What's big? Nobody knows, so everything comes back. The strong version: you send invoices up to ten thousand pounds that match the contract, on your own. Stop and ask if the amount is off from the contract by more than five percent, or if the client disputes the sign-off. Now they know exactly what's theirs. The numbers are Kestrel's, not a rule. Pick yours.

16

0:33

Four weeks off your plate.

A handover counts when it has stayed off your plate for four weeks. Not when you've explained it. Watch for the signs it's coming back: they ask permission for things inside their limit, you quietly re-check their work, or you fix things yourself instead of sending them back. If it does come back, don't take it back. Ask which step failed, and redo that one. Then, after four weeks, hand over the next thing. One at a time.

17 Finance

0:30

Turn the ball on Kestrel’s handover, quickly. Finance: invoices still have to go out on time, because cash depends on it. Commercial: the limit follows the contract terms, so someone needs to know what the contract says. Governance: who decides is now written down, with a limit. Risk: invoicing no longer depends on one person, which is the whole point. One process change touched four other parts. That’s every handover.

Close

18 1

0:46

Your turn. Take the task you wrote down at the start, the one that breaks when you’re away. One: map it, trigger, handoffs, record, then write it using the nine questions. Two: give it to someone who’s never done it, and watch them follow it once. Fix what they get stuck on. Three: hand it over using the four steps, with a decision and a limit, and put the date four weeks from now in your diary. Four: go through everyone who works for you and check the four basics. About 45 minutes for the worksheet, then the stranger test, then four weeks of leaving it alone.

19 What are you still deciding that someone else could?.

0:23

Last question. What are you still deciding that someone else could? Not doing, deciding. Write the first answer that comes to mind. If you get this module right, one recurring task stops coming back to you. Module 3 is the money. See you there.